

The Case of the Two Additional CDs

A Hercule Poirot mystery

CHARACTERS

Saurabh Kumar: CD-Content coordinator,
Upendra Singhai, Srinivasan Ramakrishnan, Ram Mohan Rao, Rahul Singh: Writers,
Sumod Hajela: Assistant Editor; **Sunil Patil:** Designer; **Garfield D'Souza, Robert Sovereign-Smith:** Copy Editors; **Hercule Poirot:** World's second best-known detective
Setting: Digit Command Centre, Navi Mumbai
Date: January 3, 2004 **Time:** 3:35 PM

Prologue: For 15 days since December 19, 2003, Saurabh Kumar dreamed of a well-deserved four-day vacation after packing off his two regular CDs to Singapore to be mastered. He foresees four days of just doing more research on the Internet, a time of peace and quiet. In short, the birds were singing, the sun was shining and all was right with Saurabh's world. Just then, Sumod calls out to him...

Sumod: Houston, we have a problem. (Saurabh's smile fades; he waits for the sledgehammer to strike his head)

Sumod: We have two more CDs to pack in for our February issue. You have to pack in the world's best-known games, and the world's best-known audio-video tutorials. And yes, I want a new design. All in nine days. (Saurabh's smile has now faded entirely. The sledgehammer did not take too long to strike).

Saurabh (to himself): Wait till I blast him on multiplayer *Quake III*. One BFG, and he's vapourised. Two new CDs in nine days! What does he think I am? Superman? (And then, the idea strikes. Why not?)

Cut to January 15, 2004. The Digit Command Centre is aghast. How could this happen? How could Saurabh do this? All for just two additional CDs?

Enter Hercule Poirot. He has been at the Digit Command Centre since January 12 ever since the execution happened. He was called in specifically to investigate the unprecedented incident.

Poirot (to all present): Eh bien, I have the answers with me. Lend me your ears (Poirot was not the one to miss the dramatic opening line). Here, let me present to you the exhibits and the suspects.

Here follows Poirot's monologue (in authentic French-Belgian accent): *Mon cher Saurabh*, you said you executed the plan with NASA-like precision (Saurabh nods; he

has no defence). But you also had accomplices, yes? (Saurabh nods again) It has not happened in the history of technology magazines before—this kind of planning put into one execution, this kind of meticulousness. So much so, *mon ami*, there is not a single shred of evidence left. But Hercule Poirot is no ordinary man, he finds what even a microscope cannot. You, *Monsieurs* Upendra and Rahul, you too were his



ILLUSTRATOR: Mahesh Benkar

chief accomplices. It was only when *Monsieur* Srinivasan got a whiff of the scheme, that he joined in, did he not?

Saurabh (interrupts): But Mr Poirot, there were also Sunil and Ram. This execution could not have been done by just three people. If I have to take the blame for all this, I better take everyone with me. And Ram did not even listen to his family who had come to meet him from down south.

Poirot (frowning): *Monsieur* Saurabh, I implore you to not disrupt my train of thought. The grey cells, they know it all. One just has to employ them. Your MP3 logs say that *Monsieur* Rahul from *Developer 2.0* magazine was playing Jagjit Singh *ghazals* even as you were doing it. Upendra was surfing the Internet, Srinivasan was downloading the incriminating data. And Ram, it was he who came back from home late in the night, only to do this. And these gentlemen, you instigated them, you brainwashed them into doing it.

The evidence is for all to see, *mon cher*.

The telephone calls, the e-mails, the meetings to execute the plot, all point to one thing—you did it. You planned this for nine days. Now, *Monsieur* Saurabh, tell me, what do you have in your defence.

Saurabh (hanging his head, nearly in tears): Yes, yes, yes, I did it. I could not take it any longer. Sumod's words had terrorised me. He made life hell. Two more CDs—1300 MB of data—in nine days. Tell me *Monsieur* Poirot, who in the world has done this? How could I not do such a thing? How could I not get accomplices?

Upendra: Saurabh, we are with you.

Srinivasan: Yes, mate, we are with you. As Axl Rose said, "Don't cry, baby, don't cry".

Saurabh (in a mood to reveal all, given the evidence): I will tell all. Yes, I asked these guys to join me in the execution. I even asked guys on the copy desk. It was a full-blown team effort. Sunil from the online team even made a design which we later HTMLised to create the perfect page. But it was the coffee that instigated us most—all of us. Even Niketu, who was ill, sent his contribution from home. All this while, it was up to me to get everyone going for the execution. And then I had a plan, why not name it? I pestered Sachin, our Features Editor, and he came up with two names—Blitzkrieg, and Sight and Sound. Blitzkrieg was surely a great name for the quick execution we planned. In the end, it was only great music, great table tennis and great food that kept us going. We would have slept through it otherwise.

Poirot: Instead, you put something else to bed, didn't you?

Saurabh: Yes, we put the two more CDs to bed. The permissions came on time, downloads happened fast, the design was scrutinised with great precision. Flash files and HTMLs were generated, content and pictures matched, and finally we burned. The planning was immaculate, the execution perfect. I plead guilty, along with Upendra, Srinivasan, Ram, Rahul Sunil, and copy-deskers Robert and Garfield, to execute these CDs. You may punish me.

Poirot: *Mon Ami* Saurabh, you are guilty, and you shall be punished. *Monsieurs* Sumod and Sachin, a pat on the backs for Saurabh and team, please.

The curtain falls. ■